

# Motoring

## Grenadier a focus on function over form

The first vehicle from Ineos is a proper honest-to-goodness off-roader. Nile Bijoux travels to Scotland to drive it.

You'd be forgiven for having no idea what Ineos is, and that's OK. I was also out of the loop on the world's third-largest chemical company, which is also run by Britain's richest man, but then it announced it was building a car.

It would be easy to dismiss Ineos as another flash in the pan, but it's serious. The Grenadier is its first effort, a proper, back-to-basics British off-roader, and we drove it through the Scottish Highlands.

**Make me an instant expert: what do I need to know?**

The Grenadier is the brainchild of Jim Ratcliffe, the aforementioned exceedingly wealthy man, who was with some mates in a pub bemoaning the demise of the Land Rover Defender – and the reduction of availability of utilitarian X4 workhorses in general.

Unlike most of us regular plebs, being a billionaire chief executive meant Ratcliffe could turn his pub-born idea into reality, and here we are now, nearly three years later.

The exterior bears more than a passing resemblance to the old Land Rover Defender, with a bit of Mercedes-Benz G-Wagen thrown in as well. It has a focus on function over form – that function being clambering over rocks and climbing mountains.

The cabin might be familiar, but the inside is brilliantly unique. Ineos' designers took inspiration from aircraft, boats and even tractors, where switches are placed for optimal control.

Buttons and switches are widely spaced and clearly labelled and auxiliary switches have been built in, pre-wired to support the addition of winches and lights and other accessories.

The steering wheel also has a

### At a glance

**Ineos Grenadier**  
**Price range:** \$94,000 to \$107,225.  
**Powertrains:** 3.0-litre turbocharged petrol straight six with 210kW/450Nm, 12.3L/100km, eight-speed automatic, 4WD. Or 3.0-litre turbocharged diesel straight six with 183kW/550Nm, 9.8L/100km, eight-speed automatic, 4WD.  
**Body style:** SUV.  
**On sale:** Soon.

Toot button, which fires one horn instead of two for a quieter, cyclist/horse-friendly alert.

Modern touches include a 12.3-inch touchscreen with Android Auto and Apple CarPlay, and an off-road navigation system that lets drivers programme, follow and record their route via waypoints.

Ineos tapped BMW for the two 3.0-litre engines, a petrol and diesel, and ZF for the eight-speed automatic gearbox (also with BMW links, evident in the shifter). Gestamp in Germany supplied the ladder frame chassis, which Ineos then fettled and developed.

Ineos also designed the manually adjustable two-speed transfer case, then had Tremec build it. A centre differential is supported by two electronically actuated differential locks supplied by Eaton. Those extra diff locks are optional too, showing how confident Ineos is in the Grenadier's capabilities.

**Where did you drive it?**

Ineos shipped us out to Scotland for a two-day journey across the Highlands to show off the



The Grenadier is Ineos' first go at a car, and it looks familiar for a reason.



The idea for the Grenadier came about, as most good ideas do, in a pub over a couple of pints.

Grenadier. Besides the weather being drizzly and miserable, it provided a great first experience as Scotland isn't too different from New Zealand in terms of driving.

The roads are broadly similar and the off-roading bits we did were not all that different to what Kiwi buyers might put the Grenadier through.

Immediately apparent was the on-road manners of the Grenadier. The steering system is an old-school box-and-beam system, which offers better control on the rougher stuff at the expense of ease-

of-use on tarmac. It can be a bit vague on the highway, requiring a small amount of tilting back and forth to keep driving straight, but it's nicely accurate when loaded up in the corners.

Despite using coil springs, as opposed to the hi-tech air suspension of the new Land Rover Defender, the ride of the Grenadier was brilliant.

But the whole point of the Grenadier is to avoid roads, and the Ardverikie Estate provided some great hills and trails to test out the differentials and transfer



There's a special wading mode, which shuts off engine fans to avoid accidentally sucking in water.

case, as well as the electronics.

The mechanicals worked an absolute treat, and the hill-descent control is the best I've experienced thus far.

It doesn't have that half-second "oh god is it actually engaged" that other systems might, working from what felt like two degrees of pitch, not to mention being brilliant at controlling the speed.

We bounced the Grenadier through the Ardverikie Estate as well as up a pretty serious trail near Loch Lomond, and didn't once feel like we were pushing its limits.



The interior is absolutely fantastic, with airplane-inspired toggles on the roof.

mushy, crying out for a little click at the end of the press. Needs better safety equipment too – the Ineos guys weren't that eager to discuss safety ratings...

### What's the pick of the range?

I drove the diesel and petrol versions, and would go for the petrol if given the choice. It did everything the diesel did off-road, is more responsive, and with diesel fuel being expensive plus the added cost of road user charges to consider...

To be fair, the diesel is very smooth and has extra torque could come in handy. Plus it might feel more familiar to die-hard off-roaders.

Each engine can be had in a base preconfigured trim levels – the Trialmaster and Fieldmaster Editions.

The Fieldmaster additions comprise the Smooth addition (better for on-road duties) and the extra off-road bits in the Trialmaster are the Rough Pack (more suited for "extreme off-roading").

Each pack can be added to the other version as well if you'd like. Check out the online configurator (at [ineosgrenadier.com/en/nz/the-vehicle/the-grenadier](https://ineosgrenadier.com/en/nz/the-vehicle/the-grenadier)) for all the ways to build a Grenadier – there are many.

### Why would I buy it?

You want a chunky, square, old-school off-roader that's still modern. You also want to be able to drive on the road without an arm workout trying to keep the thing in its lane.

### Why wouldn't I buy it?

You'd rather spend a bit extra and get the higher tech levels of the new Defender, or wait for Ineos' mooted hydrogen Grenadier, or the ute version. By the by, there is a pure-electric Ineos vehicle coming, but it'll be smaller and less focused on off-roading.

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